

56 Ruth

The foreign widow whose loyalty placed her in the family line of King David.

Ruth was a Moabite, an outsider to Israel, who lost her husband and had every reason to go home. Instead she bound herself to her bitter, grieving mother-in-law and to Naomi's God. In the fields of Bethlehem her quiet faithfulness met the kindness of Boaz, a kinsman who redeemed the family's land and married her. Her son became the grandfather of David.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Rut</i> ; meaning uncertain, perhaps "friend"
People	A Moabite, from the country east of the Dead Sea
When	c. 1100 BC, "when the judges ruled" (Ruth 1:1)
Family	Widow of Mahlon; later wife of Boaz (Ruth 4:10, 13)
Descendants	Son Obed; great-grandson King David (Ruth 4:17)
Key places	Moab, Bethlehem, Boaz's field, the city gate
Main passage	The Book of Ruth, chapters 1–4
New Testament	Named in the genealogy of Jesus (Matthew 1:5)

"Intreat me not to leave thee, or to return from following after thee: for whither thou goest, I will go ... thy people shall be my people, and thy God my God."

Ruth 1:16, KJV

The life of Ruth

The book gives places and seasons rather than exact years. The date is approximate.

c. 1100 BC <i>Days of the judges</i>	● Famine drives a family to Moab Elimelech of Bethlehem moves to Moab with his wife Naomi and their sons Mahlon and Chilion. <i>Ruth 1:1-2</i>
In Moab <i>About 10 years</i>	● Marriage and loss Ruth marries Mahlon; Orpah marries Chilion. Elimelech dies, then both sons, leaving three widows. <i>Ruth 1:3-5; 4:10</i>
On the road	● The great choice Naomi urges both daughters-in-law to go home. Orpah kisses her and returns; Ruth clings to Naomi and vows to stay. <i>Ruth 1:6-18</i>
Bethlehem <i>Barley harvest</i>	● Arrival The town stirs at their return. Naomi asks to be called Mara, "bitter," for the Almighty has dealt bitterly with her. <i>Ruth 1:19-22</i>
Boaz's field <i>Barley and wheat harvests</i>	● Gleaning Ruth gleans behind the reapers. Boaz, a relative of Elimelech, protects her and lets extra grain fall for her. <i>Ruth 2:1-23</i>
Threshing floor <i>End of harvest</i>	● A request at midnight On Naomi's advice Ruth lies at Boaz's feet and asks him to spread his covering over her as near kinsman. <i>Ruth 3:1-18</i>
City gate <i>The next day</i>	● Redeemed A nearer kinsman declines. Boaz buys Elimelech's land before the elders and takes Ruth as his wife. <i>Ruth 4:1-12</i>
Bethlehem <i>Later</i>	● A son for Naomi Ruth bears Obed. The women bless Naomi; Obed becomes the father of Jesse, the father of David. <i>Ruth 4:13-22</i>

Key activities

What Ruth did, in the order the book tells it.

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- 1 Married into an Israelite family.** As a Moabite she joined a family from Bethlehem living in her country. *Ruth 1:4; 4:10*

 - 2 Stayed when she could have left.** Orpah went back to her people; Ruth clung to Naomi. *Ruth 1:14*

 - 3 Chose Naomi's God.** She vowed to share Naomi's people, her God, and even her grave. *Ruth 1:16–17*

 - 4 Took the initiative to provide.** She asked to glean in the fields so the two widows could eat. *Ruth 2:2*

 - 5 Worked from morning to evening.** The overseer noticed she had barely rested since dawn. *Ruth 2:7, 17*

 - 6 Answered kindness with humility.** She bowed before Boaz and asked why a foreigner had found favour. *Ruth 2:10, 13*

 - 7 Shared what she was given.** She brought home her grain and saved food from her meal for Naomi. *Ruth 2:14, 18*

 - 8 Trusted Naomi's counsel.** "All that thou sayest unto me I will do." *Ruth 3:5*

 - 9 Asked Boaz to redeem.** She appealed to his role as near kinsman, and he called her a virtuous woman. *Ruth 3:9–11*

 - 10 Became a mother in David's line.** Her son Obed was the grandfather of Israel's greatest king. *Ruth 4:13, 17*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Ruth.

Old Testament

Ruth 1-4	The whole of her story
Genesis 19:36-37	Where the Moabites came from
Deuteronomy 23:3	Moabites barred from Israel's assembly
Leviticus 19:9-10	The gleaning law that fed her
Deut 25:5-10; Lev 25:25	Kinsman duties and redeeming land
1 Chronicles 2:11-15	Boaz to David; Ruth is not named

New Testament

Matthew 1:5	One of four women named in Jesus' line
Luke 3:32	Boaz and Obed appear; Ruth does not
Echo: Ephesians 2:12-19	Outsiders brought near and made fellow citizens
Echo: Galatians 4:4-5	Christ as the one who redeems

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reasons did Naomi give for sending her daughters-in-law home (Ruth 1:8-13)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Ruth stayed when Orpah, just as loving, went back?
3. *Apply:* Ruth's faith showed up as hard work and loyalty. Where could yours show up that way this week?
4. *Apply:* Who is an "outsider" in your church or neighbourhood you could welcome as Boaz welcomed Ruth?